

D233. Meaning, Consciousness, and Embodied Relevance Theory

A conceptual and philosophical companion for the Fractal Presence Framework

Document status: Conceptual/philosophical framework document. This document defines language, distinctions, and model bridges for meaning and consciousness. It is not laboratory proof, not clinical guidance, not a diagnostic instrument, not a metaphysical claim of certainty, and not a replacement for the technical theory/protocol pack.

Core sentence:

Meaning is the world becoming consequential inside a living boundary. Consciousness is the boundary becoming wide enough to know that it is being changed.

Framework version: Base Model v1.6B - Meaning and Consciousness Conceptual Integration
Prepared as an append-only conceptual layer.

1. Purpose

This document formalizes the conceptual answer to three questions: What is meaning? What is meaning to the human brain? Is consciousness the result of the evolution of meaning?

The purpose is not to prove consciousness or reduce experience to physiology. The purpose is to give the framework a disciplined philosophical grammar that can sit beside PR-AYC-G, the Autonomic Presence Index, the Decoder-Gate Principle, Cognitive Zeno-Lock, Respiratory Gate Theory, and the Neurophenomenological Presence Report layer.

Guiding boundary:
First-person experience matters, but it is not made infallible. Physiology matters, but it does not replace experience. The framework tests structured correspondence among lived report, body state, neural features, behavior, and context.

2. Information, meaning, truth, and wisdom

Information is structured difference. A phase-scrambled video, a random bit stream, a face, a memory, and a spoken apology all contain information. But information is not automatically meaningful.

Meaning is consequential structure. Information becomes meaning for a living system when it changes prediction, valuation, body state, action policy, memory, relational orientation, or self-model.

Meaning for organism i:
$$M_i(S) = || x_i(t + \Delta t) - x_i(t) ||_W$$

Here S is the incoming stimulus or event, x_i is the organism-state vector, and W is a relevance-weighting matrix. The same signal can have different meaning for different organisms because the receiver has different history, body state, memory, and current need.

Construct	Working definition	Framework distinction
Information	Structured difference in a signal, pattern, or event.	Can exist without biological consequence.
Meaning	Information that changes the receiver in relevance-weighted dimensions.	State-changing relevance.
Truth	Meaning or belief constrained by reality across time and feedback.	Separate from intensity or comfort.
Wisdom	Meaning that remains adaptive after reality testing.	Meaning plus update plus viable action.

Key distinction:
A delusion can be meaningful. A false belief can reduce uncertainty for a time. Meaning is not identical to truth. Adaptive meaning updates; delusion defends.

3. The organism-state vector of meaning

Meaning is not a single substance. It is a multi-dimensional displacement of a living system. In practical framework terms, meaning should be represented as a change-vector across several layers.

$$x_i(t) = [\text{Belief}_i, \text{Value}_i, \text{Body}_i, \text{Policy}_i, \text{Memory}_i, \text{Self}_i, \text{Relation}_i, \text{Future}_i]$$

A stimulus becomes more meaningful as it produces larger, more coherent, and more persistent changes across these dimensions. A light flicker may change sensory processing but not self-model. A story of grief or reunion may change body state, memory activation, social orientation, and future imagination at once.

Layer	Question meaning asks	Possible PR-AYC-G readout
Belief / prediction	What does this say about what is happening?	surprise, prediction update, attentional shift
Value / salience	Does this matter?	self-report meaning/empathy, salience proxies
Body / autonomic	Is this safe, threatening, or regulating?	HR, RMSSD, API_A, respiration phase
Policy / action	What options become available or closed?	option generation, task behavior, avoidance/approach
Memory	Will this be encoded or linked to prior history?	afterglow, recall, persistence, PNCC
Self / relation	Does this change who I am with respect to another?	absorption, relational availability, narrative echo

4. What meaning is to the human brain

To the human brain, meaning is embodied relevance. The brain is not merely recording the world; it is continually estimating what matters for survival, attachment, identity, memory, and future action.

A stimulus is meaningful when the nervous system cannot treat it as neutral background. It recruits attention, changes bodily readiness, assigns value, updates a model, or prepares action. The brain asks, implicitly and continuously: What is this? Is it safe? Is it mine? Is it social? Does it threaten me? Does it invite me? Must I act? Must I remember?

Working translation:

Meaning is the biological difference between data passing through a system and data reorganizing the system it passes through.

Human meaning is especially dense because it stacks sensory, social, autobiographical, symbolic, and existential relevance. A face is not only a visual object. It may be mother, judge, lover, enemy, witness, child, future, grief, or home. Human consciousness is burdened and enlarged by that stacking.

5. Decoder-Gate relation: where meaning is located

Meaning is not only in the stimulus and not only in the observer. Meaning becomes accessible at the coupling boundary between structured signal and receiver state.

$$Y(t) = G_R(t)[S(t)] + \text{epsilon}(t)$$

$$M_{\text{access}}(t) = I(M ; G_R(S))$$

The 3D-glasses analogy belongs here. The photons may already be present, but the receiver needs a compatible decoder to recover depth and structure. Likewise, a narrative may contain recoverable meaning, but the receiver must be in a state capable of decoding it. Phase scrambling degrades signal structure; analytic override changes receiver stance; fatigue, discomfort, and threat can cloud the gate.

$$M_{\text{bio}}(t) = [I(M ; G_R(S)) * API_A(t) * A_{\text{attn}}(t)] / [1 + H_{\text{ambiguity}}(t) + C_{\text{decode}}(t) + A_{\text{artifact}}(t) + O_{\text{overload}}(t) + Z_{\text{lock}}(t)]$$

This equation is conceptual and model-derived. It does not directly measure meaning. It says that accessible biological meaning should increase when latent structure is recoverable, the body is regulated, attention is available, ambiguity is low, decoding cost is tolerable, artifacts are controlled, overload is limited, and analytic measurement-lock is not dominating.

6. Meaning, measurement, and the Cognitive Zeno-Lock problem

Some forms of meaning require a reduction in cold analytic measurement long enough for integrative state-update to occur. This does not mean analysis is bad. Reflection can deepen meaning after the fact. The issue is simultaneous measurement during first contact.

The contextual override condition reveals this distinction. A person can watch the same intact story in two modes: receptive absorption or analytic partitioning. The analytic task may increase rigid phase organization while reducing local meaning-payload processing. This is a Cognitive Zeno-Lock analogy, not a demonstrated quantum mechanism.

$$\begin{aligned} Z_lock_hat &= z(PLV_gamma30-45) - z(P_gamma30-45) \\ Payload_hat &= z(P_gamma30-45) - z(PLV_gamma30-45) \end{aligned}$$

Conceptual rule:

Not all order is meaning. Some order is compliance, task-lock, defense, or forced synchrony. Living meaning requires update, participation, and enough openness for the world to matter.

7. Is consciousness the result of the evolution of meaning?

The cautious answer is: consciousness is probably not caused by meaning alone, but meaning is plausibly one of the major evolutionary pressures that shaped consciousness.

Primitive organisms must distinguish nutrient from toxin, safety from threat, approach from withdrawal. That is relevance, not human meaning. As organisms became more social, memory-dependent, predictive, and future-oriented, the amount of relevance they had to integrate increased. The receiver had to widen.

Human consciousness can therefore be framed as an expanded integrative workspace for high-density relational meaning. It binds sensation, body, memory, self, other, and future into a single updateable field.

$$C_integrative(t) \sim \text{Bind}(\text{Sensation, Body, Memory, Self, Other, Future}) \\ \text{under load, without fragmentation}$$

Philosophical thesis:

Consciousness may be the organism's high-bandwidth way of letting meaning change it without destroying it.

This remains a philosophical and model-building thesis. It is not proof that consciousness has been explained, measured, or reduced to any single EEG band, autonomic marker, respiratory rhythm, or quantum substrate.

8. Relation to PR-AYC-G

PR-AYC-G becomes the experimental doorway into this philosophical question. It does not ask whether meaning is metaphysically ultimate. It asks whether high-density narrative meaning leaves measurable traces in the body-brain system beyond matched sensory energy and analytic task demand.

PR-AYC-G component	Meaning question	Expected bounded readout
Phase-scrambled control	Is raw sensory energy enough without decodable structure?	low meaning reports, low payload/carryover if structure is destroyed
Target 1	What happens when intact meaning is received in a receptive state?	higher meaning/empathy/absorption, API_A, low-gamma payload, PNCC
Contextual override	What happens when the same stimulus is measured analytically?	higher task effort, possible higher gamma PLV / Z_lock, lower payload
Washout	Does meaning persist after stimulus offset?	afterglow, PNCC_theta, PNCC_A, return-to-baseline geometry
Respiratory gate	Does breath phase alter meaning access or gamma payload?	respiration-corrected payload and API models

This turns the philosophical definition of meaning into a staged empirical question: not whether meaning is fully captured by sensors, but whether meaning produces a repeatable, artifact-controlled, respiration-aware state transition across self-report, autonomic, spectral, and recovery layers.

9. Expected dissociations

A mature theory of meaning must expect dissociations. Meaning can be reported without clean physiology. Physiology can shift without reported meaning. Arousal can be intense without integration. Low arousal can reflect boredom rather than presence. These dissociations are not failures if they are anticipated and used to constrain the model.

Dissociation	Interpretation	Framework response
High report, noisy physiology	The experience may be real but unmeasured, artifact-contaminated, or routed through an unmodeled pathway.	mark exploratory; inspect artifact, respiration, task notes, and qualitative report
High physiology, low report	Compliance, relaxation without meaning, threat, fatigue, or poor construct mapping.	do not call it meaning without report/behavioral support
High gamma PLV, low meaning	Task-lock or forced coherence rather than living meaning.	classify under measurement-lock unless payload/self-report support appears
Low HR, low meaning	Under-engagement, boredom, sleepiness, or relaxation.	API_A alone is not presence
High meaning, low API_A	Activating or dysregulating meaning, not regulated absorption.	separate intensity from integration

10. Falsifiable bridge claims

Although this document is conceptual, it still defines empirical bridges that can be constrained.

- If self-reported meaning is fully explained by demand, expectancy, mood, or familiarity and not by preregistered model components, the first-person meaning bridge is constrained.
- If phase-scrambled controls produce the same meaning reports, API_A, low-gamma payload, and carryover as intact targets, the claim that decodable structure matters is weakened.
- If contextual override does not alter task reports, gamma PLV, payload proxy, API_A, or behavior relative to target, the analytic measurement-lock model is weakened.
- If low-gamma payload disappears after respiration, EMG/EOG, motion, and artifact matching, it should not be interpreted as a semantic payload marker.

- If high meaning repeatedly fails to alter memory, policy, body state, report, or future action better than neutral controls, the consequential-update definition is weakened.

11. Non-claims and prohibited interpretations

- This document does not prove consciousness.
- It does not reduce meaning to HRV, EEG, low-gamma power, respiration, or self-report.
- It does not claim that meaning has literal mass. It claims that meaning can have causal weight for a living system.
- It does not claim that analysis destroys meaning. It claims that simultaneous cold measurement can interrupt first-contact integrative meaning in some contexts.
- It does not claim that adaptive meaning is always positive, pleasant, or comforting.
- It does not claim that delusion is meaningless. It distinguishes meaning from truth-tracking and adaptive viability.
- It does not turn philosophical language into a clinical intervention or moral command structure.

12. Framework integration statement

This document should be appended as D233 under the conceptual/philosophical layer of the framework. It integrates with The Living Map, the Neurophenomenological Presence Report layer, PR-AYC-G v1.6, Autonomic Presence Index theory, Decoder-Gate Theory, Cognitive Zeno-Lock, Respiratory Gate Theory, and the Measurement Ontology.

Canonical integration:

Meaning = relevance-weighted organism-state displacement.

Presence = ordered availability under load.

Consciousness = candidate evolved integrative bandwidth for high-density relational meaning.

Truth = reality-constrained update across time.

Wisdom = adaptive meaning that survives feedback.

The framework should treat this layer as a philosophical companion and construct-definition layer. It may guide hypotheses, reports, protocols, and public-facing explanations. It should not be used to inflate empirical claims beyond what the measurement layers can support.

13. Final synthesis

Meaning is the world becoming consequential inside a living boundary.

To the human brain, meaning is embodied relevance: a signal that must be metabolized because it changes what matters, what is possible, what is remembered, or what must be done.

Consciousness may be the evolved integrative field that allows a living system to bind sensation, body, memory, self, other, and future into a unified space where meaning can update without immediate fragmentation.

Final sentence:

Meaning is not the opposite of measurement. Meaning is what measurement must learn not to destroy while trying to understand it.